Madhya-desa or Middle India, including most of the Buddhist pilgrimage places such as Sarnath, Sravasti, Lumbini, Kushinagar, Vaishali, Pataliputra (Patna), Nalanda, Rajgir and Bodh Gaya.

All the Central Asian towns listed above, and many others, were renowned Buddhist centres before they were transformed into centres of Arab rule and Islamic learning. The name of the historic Central Asian town Bokhara, for example, is derived from the word Vihara, or monastery. Several oasis towns fell into ruins and were reclaimed by the desert. They were later excavated by archaeologists like Aurel Stein and Paul Pelliot. Stein called this entire Central Asian zone ‘Serindia’.

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I travelled to the ancient cities of Gaochang and Jiaohe, not far from the present town of Turfan, in 1984. They still contained the ruins of several pagodas and city walls and arched gates, bearing witness to more flourishing times. I also visited the famous Dunhuang grottoes in Kansu province, which lay a short distance from Jiayuguan, the starting point of the caravan routes to Central Asia. These appear to be inspired by the Indian cave temples at Ajanta and Ellora. They are a virtual repository of fresco paintings, sculpture and architecture influenced by Indian, Central Asian and Chinese motifs and styles, and stretch over the period from the fourth century to the eleventh century CE when they were abandoned, as Central Asian trade and travel diminished and then died out. The earliest figures of Lord Buddha and devotees have either Indian or Central Asian features. The influence of Gandhara art is unmistakable in the older caves, with the Buddha statues draped in diaphanous folds typical of that art. By the time we come to caves dating from the Tang dynasty (618–906 CE) the facial features are characteristically Chinese, as are the costumes worn by various figures. Over the centuries there was a steady Sinicization of style, just as Buddhism itself took on a more distinctively Chinese expression.

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